SENNA

Bedtime dose

Opioid constipation

CHEMICAL NAME Sennosides A and B (dianthrone glycosides from *Cassia/Senna alexandrina*)
CLASS Stimulant laxative (anthraquinone)
TRADE NAMES Senokot · Ex-Lax · Sennalax · Pursennid

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Constipation.
- Opioid-induced constipation (prophylaxis with stool softener).
- Bowel preparation (high doses).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** tablets or syrup at bedtime.

DOSAGES

- **Adult:** 7.5–15 mg sennosides at night (2–4 tablets of 7.5 mg); max 30 mg.
- **Children 2–4 yr:** 3.75–7.5 mg; 4–6 yr 3.75–15 mg; 6–18 yr 7.5–30 mg once daily.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 8–12 h.
- Not absorbed; converted by colonic bacteria to active rhein anthrone.
- Excreted in faeces; small amount in urine (may colour urine).

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Assess bowel pattern; prescribe with opioids.
- Rule out obstruction.
- Monitor K^+ in long-term use.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Stimulates **colonic motility** and fluid secretion → bowel evacuation.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Abdominal cramps.
- Diarrhoea.
- Urine discoloration (yellow-brown or red).

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Hypokalaemia with chronic abuse.
- Melanosis coli (benign pigmentation).
- Perianal skin blistering in nappy-wearing children (prolonged contact).

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Intestinal obstruction; acute abdominal pain of unknown cause.
- Inflammatory bowel disease flare.
- Severe dehydration.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Diuretics, steroids, digoxin:** hypokalaemia risk.
- Additive with other laxatives.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take at bedtime; expect results next morning.
- Urine may change colour.
- Increase fluids and fibre.
- Do not use long-term without advice.

KEY POINTS

- Anthraquinone stimulant laxative.
- Standard with opioids.
- Bedtime — works in 8–12 h.
- Avoid in obstruction.